

## Bad

“Let me tell you, buddy, I’m pretty displeased to learn that you’re quittin’ this great job. Or, really, this not-so-great job, but it was great because you were here, buddy ol’ pal ol’ chum. You made these days in the slimy sewers-of-war just that much more bearable – you know I depended on you? I *depended* on you to make this job survivable? On those days when I was knee-deep in sewage, shootin’ a mutant fly into little bits of brown sticky fly bits, you know why I didn’t just give up? It’s because YOU were there. But now you’re leavin’? Now you’re leavin’ and I have no sewer support buddy? I’m just a War Plumber times one?

“Do you know how that makes me feel? Let me tell you in verbose, explicit detail how that makes me feel. Bad! And maybe even, sad. Yeah. How’s that. Some buddy you are, to make me feel bad and sad at the same time. That verisimilitude of very vile days, you curse it upon *my* name, *my* family? Fuck you, pal! I curse it on *your* name, and *your* family. Gosh, I’m so fuming mad I can’t even think straight! I think I’m saying some things I’m going to regret. Ah geez. Ahhhh geez. Come here buddy. You know I can’t be mad at you. You know what? It’s OK that you’re leaving, because we’ll be buddies forever. I’m glad we have the healthy kind of relationship where we can sort that out real good, y’know?”

“Yeah, I agree,” said the other guy. And then they made out in the sewers, as was the War Plumber tradition.

## Good

Lenaulto heaved the heavy dripping sack from off his shoulder and into the industrial alligator-grade meat grinder.

“These gators, don’t matter none what we seem to do or how hard we work this nasty thankless job, they always seem to come back, don’t they?”

Avaretti crossed his bulky forearms and nodded sagely.

“Yep, yep, it’s true. Gator infestations don’t stay gone. It’s ‘cuz these mutant gators, see, they got mutant eggs. They spread like pathogens in the water. Microscopic level, like sea monkeys. Can’t fockin’ see ‘em. It’s the worst.”

With the bag successfully being turned into whatever comes out the other end of a grinder, Lenaulto dusted off his hands and spoke in a slight yell as to overpower the horrible churning noise coming from within the machine.

“But I tell you, I’ll always take the gators over the bugs. The gators stay in the water, y’know? You can scoop him out with a net, or reach in there with a machete, or just blast down with our Plumbing-Grade Shotguns. The insects, they’s itchy, and they’s all over the place. Bylegh. Can’t stand it.”

Avaretti nodded again, the sagacity of his look beginning to fade into something else, something not quite obvious to Lenaulto.

“Yes, those insects are a pain.”

“Yeah, they really are. You gotta take ‘em in teams of two. One wit’ the smoke to give ‘em good dreams, one wit’ the flamethrower to turn them to lil’ wisps of smoke. I tell you

somethin', Avy, we make quite a team. If it weren't for yous, I'da quit this job a long time'a go."

Finally, Avaretti's facial expression broke down into a more discernible expression: guilt, maybe mixed with a couple ounces of sorrow.

"Yeah... well... about that, Lenny..."

Lenaulto bolted upright as if struck by lightning. The hairs on his ostentatious moustache stood on end.

"No... no no no... no, I've heard that talk before, Avy! That's the talk of an apprentice steppin' out on me! Not yous too, you know the world needs us War Plumbers, and how manys left of us are there to do a good honest days of work?"

Avaretti's voice turned hoarse. "I'm sorry, Lenny, really, I am. Bein' a War Plumber wit' ya, well, it wasn't always glamorous, but it felt like it meant somethin'. ...But they're sendin' me back home now. They're sayin' I can't stay in the city, 'cuz the population's getting' too overran with those who don't help the economy none, see. So they're sendin' me back home to my momma.

"Funny... I always though if I were going to be sent back home to my momma, it'd be in a box, covered in Exploding Sewer Urchin needles."

Lenaulto was shaking now. His faced turned a hue of red, as was his habit when anything really bothered him. And it didn't matter what was bothering him, it would be felt by those around him.

“BUT YOU’RE A FECKIN’ WAR PLUMBER! They can’t just boot ya out! The city needs us! Unless, ohhh ho ho ho, unless they WANT to get overran with the ghoulies and monsters that THEY created!” Lenaulto tried to make eye contact with Avaretti. “You gotta fight it, Avy, you gotta tell ‘em to knock it off! Tell ‘em how important you are!”

Avaretti shook his head.

“I’m sorry, Lenny, but... it’s final. They put the stamp on it. You know it. The Stamp.”

“The Stamp...” Lenaulto rasped, slapping his bulbous hairy hand to his bulbous exposed forehead.